



FELDMANDAXON
PARTNERS INC.

Tackling Tough Interview Questions

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Tough Interview Questions



What are the
top tough
interview
questions?



What makes an
interview
question tough?



What are the
top four?



How to answer
behavioural
style questions



What are the top tough
interview questions?



What makes an interview
question tough?



What are the
top four?



The Top 4 Tough Questions

Tell me about yourself.

What is your greatest weakness?

What are your salary expectations?

Why should we hire you?

1. Tell Me About Yourself

Have you been asked this question in an interview?



Common Mistakes

1. Resume Rehash

- Many candidates respond by launching into a recitation of their resume from the very beginning. That can turn into a very long monologue.



Common Mistakes

2. Modesty

- Many candidates make the mistake of being too modest. They reply with a humble or vague introduction that fails to communicate their strongest qualifications clearly.
- If you take time to prepare, you can find a way to present yourself to full advantage while staying true to your personality.
- Don't be afraid to use the word "I."



Common Mistakes

3. Rambling

- Many suitable candidates mess up this question because of **overthinking** and **talking too much** without an approach.



Use This Question to Your Advantage

- You only get one chance to make a good first impression.
- Your chance to carefully curate your brand what you want that first impression to be.



Use This Question to Your Advantage

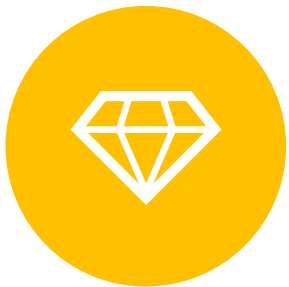
This question is an opportunity to market yourself:



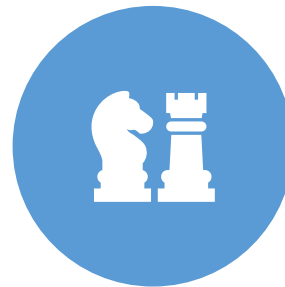
Convince the interviewer you are the best candidate



Demonstrate how you are unique



Articulate how your particular combination of skills, strengths and experience work together to deliver value



Promote aspects of your background that match the requirements of the role

Use This Question to Your Advantage

- You may be asked this question in a networking or social setting.
- Can expand or contract depending on situation.



What Interviewers Look For

When interviewers ask you this question, they want to discover the following:

- What qualities make you a great fit for the job?
- Why are you interested in the role?
- Why are you interested in the company or the industry?
- What unique feature do you possess that makes you stand out from other candidates?



Dive right in
with the three-
step approach.



Three Step Process for Creating Your Response

Present

- Who I Am Today

Past

- How I Got Here (background, career history, leaving story)

Future

- What's Next

Present – I Am

- Number of Years Experience
- Industry Exposure
- Areas of Expertise
- 3-4 Key Strengths
- Most Recent Position
- Interests/Passion
- Areas of Knowledge
- Specialized Training/Certification



Past – How I Got Here

BACKGROUND

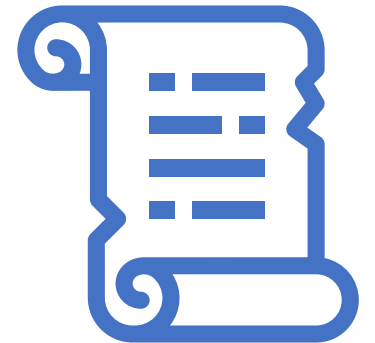
- Education / Certification
- Volunteer Work
- Interests / Activities / Associations
- Travel / International Experience

CAREER HISTORY

- Company / Positions
- Brief Synopsis of Responsibilities
- Accomplishments / Success Stories
- Skills Learned or Developed

LEAVING STORY

- Keep it Brief
- Be Positive
- Be Relaxed
- Depersonalize



Future – What's Next

WHAT I BRING:

- Strengths
- Knowledge
- Expertise

WHAT I AM LOOKING FOR:

- Culture
- Management Style
- Size of Organization
- Structure of Organization
- Values



Example

I am an active member with the HRPAs who has over 10 years of experience managing all aspects of HR operations, from recruitment, training and development to performance management and labour relations across Fortune 500 companies.

Over the last six years with x company I have been responsible for developing, implementing, evaluating and improving a number of the organizations policies, procedures and metrics. These efforts have resulted in a 30% reduction in the time-to-fill ratio for recruitment and the successful adoption of an applicant tracking system.

I am really excited about this opportunity because I believe that my experience has prepared me to make an immediate contribution to your team, especially with your need to identify and implement a new HRIS and the upcoming rebuild of your performance management program.

Answering Tell Me About Yourself

Summary

Questions?

Are you better equipped to handle this question?

2. What is Your Biggest Weakness?



Responses to Avoid

- Naming a skill that is a **requirement** for the job.
- Saying you have **NO** weaknesses.
- Sharing a weakness that is **impossible** to improve upon.
- Giving a **weak answer** with the hopes of making yourself look good.



Two-Part Answer

Part 1: Your Weakness

- Briefly describe a real weakness that would not be a major impediment for the role.

Part 2: Improvement

- Discuss your proactive efforts to improve. Give tangible examples of your progress.

Part 1: How to Choose a “Good” Weakness



Be authentic. Don't select a weakness just because it sounds good. You will make a better impression with sincerity.



Pick a weakness that is acceptable for the job at hand. Be aware of the job requirements and don't cite a weakness related to any of the required skills or desired qualities.



Select a weakness that is relatively minor and “fixable.” By fixable, it's something you can improve through work and motivation.

Example of a “Fixable” Weakness

Fixable	Harder to Fix
<i>“I get nervous when speaking in front of large groups.”</i> • You can get better through practice and learning new skills — and this is a common development area.	<i>“I am very shy and often have trouble speaking up in meetings.”</i> • While there’s nothing wrong with being shy, an interviewer could assume that the candidate would have trouble collaborating in a team environment. This is a preference or personality quality that would be more difficult to change.

Part 2: How to Demonstrate You are Working on Your Weakness

In the second part of your answer, you need to describe how you have already taken steps to improve in your area of weakness.

It demonstrates:



You're looking for ways to learn and grow



You're taking the initiative to improve

Weakness Example: Delegation

PART 1

"I think one area I could work on is my delegation skills. I am always so concerned about everything being done right and on time that I can get stuck in that mentality of "If you want it done right, do it yourself." Unfortunately, that's not always possible and I've realized that I can slow things down if I am too controlling."

PART 2

"I learned this recently when given the opportunity to manage the department's summer interns. I had never managed direct reports before, so this was a hugely educational experience in many different ways. It taught me through delegation, I am giving others learning opportunities and I am able to focus on my priorities. I know that I can benefit from additional development in this area, so I signed up for a management skills training course and am always looking for opportunities to manage projects for our group."

Weakness Example: Technical Skills

PART 1

“One area where I recognize I have room for improvement is my proficiency with advanced Excel functions, specifically pivot tables and VLOOKUP. While I understand the basic functions and can perform essential tasks, I haven’t had a chance to work with more advanced features.”

PART 2

“To address this, I have already enrolled in an online Excel course focused on these advanced skills. I am actively working through practical exercise and tutorials. I believe that gaining these skills will significantly contribute to my ability to analyze data more efficiently and make more informed decisions.”

Weakness Example: Public Speaking

PART 1

I would say that public speaking is an area that I could work on. I tend to get nervous when asked to present to a large group of people. In small team meetings, I'm the first one to stand up and present. But put me in front of a big group and I can get flustered.

PART 2

"I spoke to my manager about this, and we set it as one of my development goals for this year. I took an internal presentation skills class and attended some meetings of Toastmasters, a networking group for people who want to practice public speaking. With some practice, I started to feel more comfortable. Recently, I even volunteered to represent our team at a division-wide town hall. I only had to present for 10 minutes, but I did it and got great feedback! I plan on continuing to seek out opportunities to improve in this area."

Answering What is Your Greatest Weakness

Summary

Questions?

Are you better equipped to handle this question?

3. What are Your Salary Expectations?



Salary Expectations

Never bring up the salary topic – always allow the interviewer to do it first. Employers will bring up the topic of salary at some point in the interview process.

Employers use salary as a gauge to see if you are a suitable candidate, within their budget and at the right level, for the position.

You can manage this stress by preparing your answers to salary-related questions ahead of time. If you do research on average compensation for both the role and your experience level, you can have productive and informative conversations about pay with your potential employers.

Options for Answering the Questions

- **Offer a range.** Even if you start by emphasizing your flexibility, most employers will still want to hear specific numbers. In this case, offer them a range (plus or minus about \$10,000-\$20,000). This will allow you to remain flexible while still giving the employer a clear answer. You can create this range based on research or your own experience in the industry.
- **Only give numbers you'd be happy with.** Only offer a range that gives you the means to support yourself and your family.
- **Highlight your skills.** In your answer, you can subtly emphasize why you're a good fit for the position. You can say something like, *"Based on my 10 years of experience in this field, I would expect a salary in the range of \$Y to \$Z."*
- If you have some idea regarding the pay for the position: *"Based on the information I have about the position, a salary in the range of X and Y would reflect the experience and expertise that I would bring to the role."*
- If the salary range is already stated in the job description, then you can answer that you are willing to consider any offer stated in the job description as: *"The job description says that the salary will be around xx - xx. I am looking at X dollars."*
- If you want to play safe, you can answer as: *"I would expect to be paid competitively and commensurate with the level of experience."*

What Not to Say

- **Avoid giving a set amount.** If you can avoid mentioning a specific salary until after the employer mentions it, negotiation will be more in your favor.
- **Do not price yourself out of a job.** Do not ask for a much larger salary if your research shows the job is worth half of that. You may price yourself out of a job offer if you come in too high.



Answering What are Your Salary Expectations

Summary

Questions?

Are you better equipped to handle this question?

4. Why Should We Hire You?



Remember
that all
questions
asked in an
interview
should answer
this question.



Why is This Question Asked?

- Candidates that make it to the interview stage are qualified for the job. **The winning candidate must be more than qualified**, especially in a very competitive job market.
- Employers want to **make sure you know what they want and that you can provide it.**
- They want to make sure **you understand what they do and that you are a cultural match.**
- You must **use your interview** to get your employer to see that **you are the one who will best fit.**
- Make the **interviewer's job easier** by convincing them that:
 - You can do the work and deliver exceptional results
 - You will fit in and be a great addition to the team
 - You possess a combination of skills and experience that make you stand out

Your Answer Should



Show that you have skills and experience to do the job and deliver great results.



Highlight that you will fit in and be a great addition to the team.



Describe how hiring you will make an impact and help them achieve more.

Three Steps to Answering the Question

1

Step 1: Brainstorm

2

Step 2: Structure
Your Answer

3

Step 3: Practice!

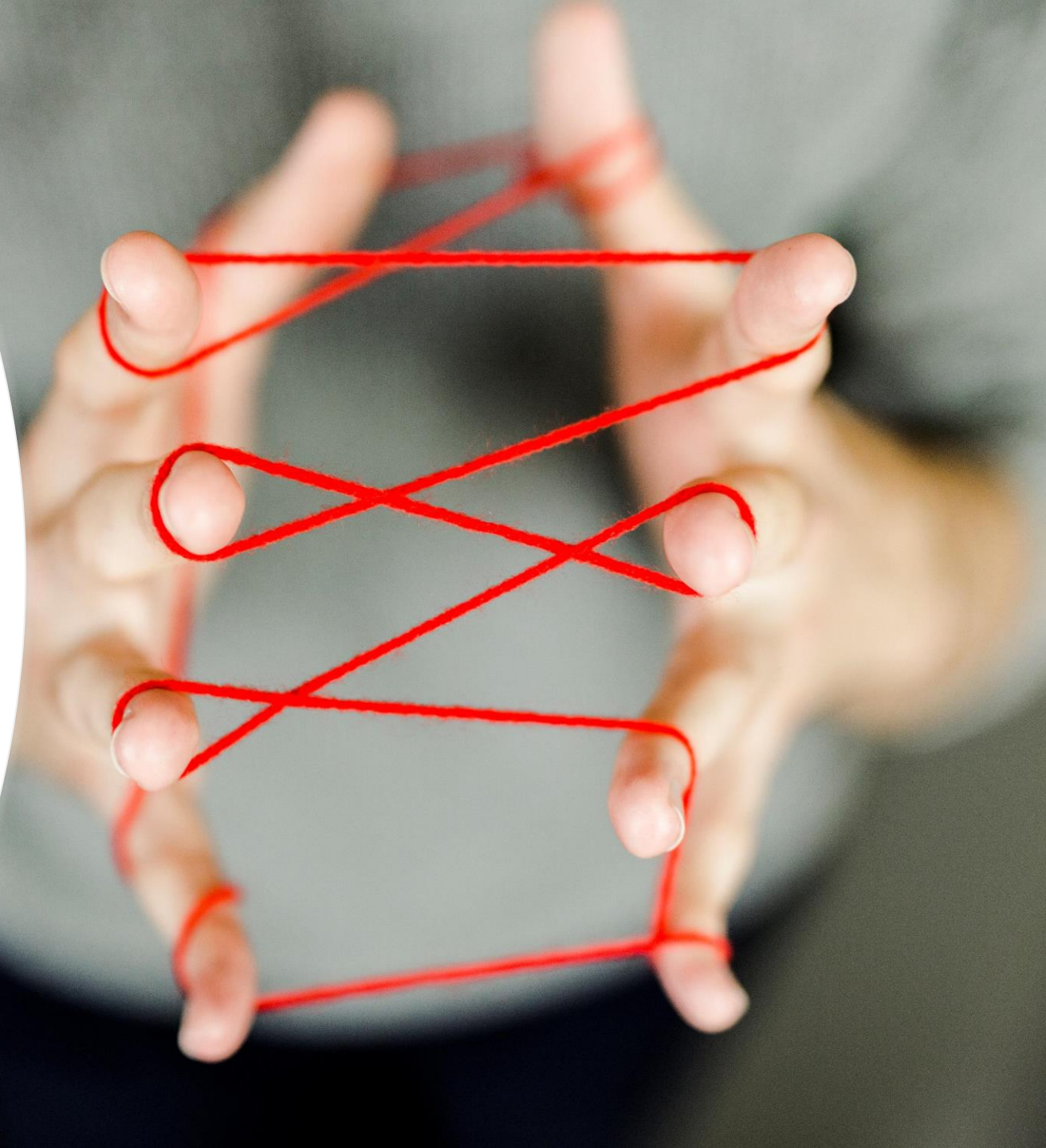
Step 1: Brainstorm

- To get started, review the job description and your resume and ask yourself these questions:
 - What are the most important qualifications for this position from the company's perspective?
 - In which of these areas do I really shine?
 - What are my most impressive accomplishments?
 - What makes me different from the typical candidate?



Step 2: Structure Your Answer

- Choose the 3-4 bullet points that make the strongest argument for you. Use those bullet points to structure your points. Don't write a script to memorize — simply capture the bullet points that you want to convey. Each bullet will describe a brief explanation and/or example for context.
- Keep it concise.
- Demonstrate to them what you will bring to the position.
- What sets you apart from the competition and explain why your background and experience would be a good fit for this job.



Step 3: Practice

- It is not a good idea to memorize a script — you can end up sounding like a robot or feel more nervous because of pressure to remember specific wording.
- The better approach is to capture your bullet points, study them, and then practice until you feel comfortable talking about them off the cuff.



Answering Why Should We Hire You

Summary

Questions?

Are you better equipped to handle this question?

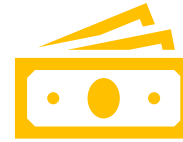
Summary



Tell me about
yourself.



What is your
greatest weakness?



What are your salary
expectations?



Why should we hire
you?

Bonus: How to Answer Behavioural- Style Interview Questions Using the STAR Technique



What is the STAR Technique?



S **SITUATION**

Describe the situation in a concise and relevant way. Keep it factual and don't include your feelings about the situation.

Example: Last year, my team faced a critical project deadline.



T **TASK**

Explain your role and responsibilities. Clarify the task at hand. Avoid including irrelevant details.

Example: As the team leader I was responsible for ensuring we met the deadline.



A **ACTION**

Describe the steps you took to address the issue. Focus on your actions, not the teams.

Example: I organized daily stand-up meetings and delegated tasks efficiently.



R **RESULT**

Highlight the outcomes and results from the company's perspective. Quantify your achievements if possible.

Example: As a result, we completed the project 2 days ahead of schedule and increased client satisfaction by 20%.

STAR Example

Question: "Describe a situation where you had to lead a team. What was the outcome?"

Situation: "During my time as a team leader at my previous company, we were tasked with improving the efficiency of our customer service department."

Task: "My task was to lead a team of five to analyze our current processes, identify bottlenecks, and implement solutions to reduce response times and increase customer satisfaction."

Action: "I began by conducting one-on-one meetings with each team member to gather their insights and identify any recurring issues. We then mapped out the entire customer service process and pinpointed specific areas for improvement. I delegated specific tasks to each team member based on their strengths and organized weekly check-ins to monitor progress and address any obstacles."

Result: "Within three months, we reduced our average response time by 40% and increased our customer satisfaction score by 15%. The improvements we implemented were adopted company-wide, significantly enhancing overall service efficiency."

To become a
real pro at
handling these
questions,
attend our
Behavioural
Interviewing
webinar!





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